How to Make 3D Story Shorts with Claude: Step-by-Step Guide

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One skill turns a topic into a finished 60-second Short: a true fact told as a mini-movie, with cartoon characters in busy 3D worlds and one-word captions. You pick, approve, and press one button.

1. What you'll make and what you need

You get a vertical 9:16 Short of about 60 seconds: a true, surprising story with cartoon characters in bright 3D worlds, a moving camera, a voiceover, and one-word captions. Claude researches, writes, builds and checks it. Your computer only does the final render, which takes about 2 minutes.

You need	Why	How to get it
A Claude account (Free, Pro, Max or higher)	Runs the skill	claude.ai
Code execution turned on	Skills need it	Settings > Capabilities > Code execution and file creation (called "Create and edit files" in newer layouts)
The skill file `3d-story-shorts.zip`	The method + starter project	Download link in the video description
Node.js LTS (free)	Renders the video on your computer	nodejs.org
A Windows PC or a Mac	The final render	Any normal PC with a graphics card works
Optional: the Claude desktop app	Lets Claude put the project straight into a folder on your computer and check the finished video for you	Download it from claude.ai

You need	Why	How to get it
Optional: a voice	Your own recording, or a text-to-speech tool you've connected	-

2. Install the skill in Claude (one time)

1. Download `3d-story-shorts.zip`. **Don't unzip it.** Claude needs the zip itself.
2. In Claude, check **Settings > Capabilities**: code execution / file creation must be on.
3. Go to **Customize > Skills**.
4. Click **+**, then **+ Create skill**, then **Upload a skill**.
5. Choose `3d-story-shorts.zip`. The skill appears in your list. Make sure its toggle is **on**.

If the upload fails, the usual cause is a re-zipped folder. Use the original zip exactly as downloaded. Official steps: Use skills in Claude.

3. Make your first video (in the chat)

Start a **new chat** and type:

```
Use the 3d-story-shorts skill to make me a Short about [your topic]. My audience is [who].
```

Good topics are hidden science, clever loopholes, old inventions, and engineering stories. Claude then walks you through four approvals.

1. **Pick an idea.** Claude researches and gives you 5 true stories, each with a hook, what happens on screen, and the twist. Reply with the number you want, or give your own idea.
2. **Approve the script.** You get a shot table (time, line, what's on screen) and a fact list with sources. Ask for changes in plain words ("make the hook stronger", "remove the like-and-subscribe line"), then say **yes**.
3. **Pick the voice.**
   - **Your own voice:** record the script from the voice-over PDF, save it as a WAV or MP3, and attach it in the chat.

- **An AI voice:** if you have a voice tool connected, Claude plays you 3 short samples. Pick one, and Claude reads the whole script in that one voice.

4. **Let Claude build.** Claude builds the 3D video and checks a frame from every shot. You'll see a preview image of the frames. Ask for changes ("make the office busier", "bigger characters") before rendering.

At the end, Claude either puts the project folder on your computer (desktop app with a folder added) or gives you a zip. If you get a zip: right-click it, choose **Extract All**, then **Extract**. It won't run from inside the zip.

To let Claude put the project on your computer and check the finished video itself, use the **Claude desktop app**. When Claude asks for folder access, allow it. Your Videos folder works well.

4. Render the video

First: install Node.js (one time)

1. Go to **nodejs.org** and download the **LTS** version. Install it with the default options.
2. Check that it worked:
   - **Windows:** press the Windows key, type `cmd`, press Enter, type `node -v`, and press Enter.
   - **Mac:** open Terminal, type `node -v`, and press Enter.
3. You should see a version number like `v22.11.0`. If it says "not recognized", restart your computer and try again.

Windows

1. Hold the **Windows key** and press **R**.
2. Paste the path to `render.bat` and press **Enter**. If the project is in your Videos folder:

```
%USERPROFILE%\Videos\[project folder]\render.bat
```

(Or open the project folder and double-click **render**, the file with the gear icon.)

3. If **"Windows protected your PC"** appears, click **More info**, then **Run anyway**.
4. A black window opens:
   - **[1/4]** installing tools (the first time only, a few minutes);
   - **[3/4]** rendering, with the frame count going up to about 1,900;

- **[4/4]** adding the voiceover.

5. When it says **DONE - your video is final.mp4 in this folder**, press any key. `final.mp4` is in the project folder. Each new render keeps your previous video as `final_previous.mp4`.

Mac

1. Open **Terminal**.
2. Type `bash ` (with a space after it), then drag `render.sh` from the project folder into the Terminal window, and press **Enter**.
3. Wait for **DONE**. `final.mp4` appears in the project folder.

How long it takes: on a PC with a good graphics card, about 2 minutes for a 60-second video. Older laptops can take 10 minutes or more.

5. Fixes for common problems

What you see	What it means	What to do
"14 vulnerabilities" or "npm warn install-scripts esbuild"	Normal notices from the tools	Ignore them. **Don't** run `npm audit fix --force`
"The system cannot find the path specified" at step 2	Harmless on some npm versions	Ignore it
It downloads the browser, then the frame count never appears	The render browser was half-unpacked	`render.bat` retries by itself. If it still fails, run `check.bat` and send Claude the file `out\check_log.txt` (or just say "checked" if Claude has folder access)
"RENDER FAILED"	Something went wrong while drawing frames	Run `check.bat`, then send Claude `out\check_log.txt`
Your browser says it can't download a `.bat` file	Windows blocks single `.bat` downloads	Ask Claude for the whole project as a zip, or let Claude write it into your folder (desktop app)

What you see	What it means	What to do
"node is not recognized"	Node.js isn't installed, or needs a restart	Install the LTS version from nodejs.org, then restart
The captions are slightly out of sync	The words in the script don't match the recording	Tell Claude which line. It re-times everything from the real audio
The video looks empty or dull	A shot needs more props	Tell Claude which shot and what feels off. It adds props and light, and moves the camera closer

6. Tips for a channel in this style

- **Real fact + story + twist.** True hidden facts told as a mini-movie get the most views in this format. Plain explainers with no story, and pure made-up stories, do much worse.
- **The hook is the first sentence:** a strange action plus one exact detail ("They painted the jail cell pink."). No intros.
- **Make every video different.** Change the topic, the locations, the characters' colours and the camera moves. YouTube's monetization rules don't reward repetitive, mass-produced uploads.
- **Never copy another creator's scripts, characters or exact scenes.** Use the style idea only. The skill makes its own characters and sets.
- **Keep it accurate.** Claude checks every claim against two sources and lists them in `script.md`. Keep that list. If a story adds invented characters around a real fact, don't present the invented parts as history.
- **Stay safe for ads:** no medical or money advice, no fake quotes from real people, no graphic injury.
- **AI voice:** when you upload, check YouTube Studio's current rules on disclosing altered or synthetic content, and follow them.
- **Post on a schedule** and track which topics hold viewers to the end. Feed the winners back to Claude: "make another one like the skyscraper video".